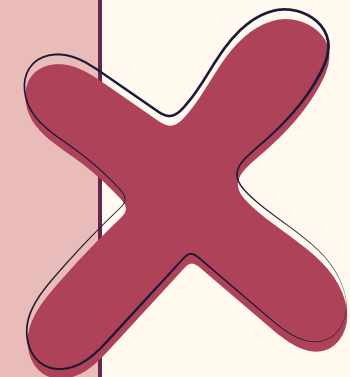




DEARLY BELOVED, YOU'VE HURT ME

A study on gendered social dynamics and
interpersonal forgiveness and leniency

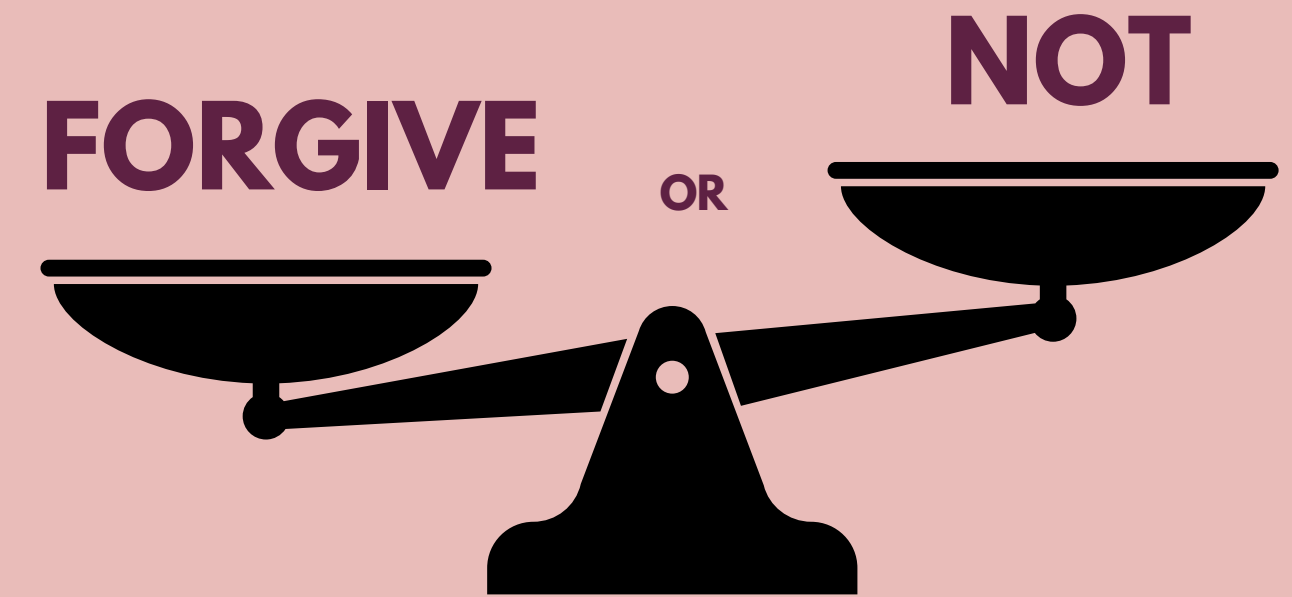


THE FRAGILITY OF TRUST

Relationships rely on trust. When trust is fractured, forgiveness becomes the critical mechanism for repair or termination.

Key Distinction:

Forgiveness $\neq$ Reconciliation



PREDICTING FORGIVENESS

Dispositional Factors

Skalski-Bednarz et al (2024)

- *Decisional Forgiveness* → Agreeableness
- *Emotional Forgiveness* → Extraversion, Emotional Stability

Tsang and Stanford (2007)

- Empathy and Religiousness increase forgiveness likelihood

Situational Factors

Fehr et al. (2010); Zahorcova et al. (2023)

- Situational factors account for a greater portion of the variance

Important Situational Variables

- Offender's intent
- severity of apology
- nature of offense

RELATIONAL AND GENDER DYNAMICS

Relational Context

- High quality relationships promote forgiveness (Fincham et al., 2002)

Gendered Differences

- Overall gender differences are minimal (Miller et al., 2008)
- Gender motivations for unforgiveness exist:
 - Men → tool for offender reform
 - Women → means of protection



OBJECTIVE & HYPOTHESIS

How does
Harm Level
Relationship Type
Gender Dynamics
shape our forgiveness responses?

1. **High Harm scenarios will elicit lower levels of leniency and forgiveness**
2. **Participants will be less forgiving towards a best friend compared to a romantic partner in the high harm scenario.**
3. **Female Participants will show less leniency (less forgiving) compared to male participants.**

PARTICIPANTS

- **112 total participants**
 - Incomplete answers (15)
- **97 valid participants**
 - 194 data points; 40 male, 56 female
- **Undergraduate students mostly from the 5cs, with a few exceptions**
- **Participants collected through:**
 - Sona Systems
 - Distribution of Qualtrics Survey



METHODOLOGY

2 x 3 x 2 x 2 Factorial Design

Procedure

- A total of 97 participants were presented two scenarios:
 - **1 low harm (Bad-mouthing)**
 - **1 high harm (Financial betrayal)**
- Participants were encouraged to vividly picture themselves in each scenario to accurately depict reactions
- All scenarios were kept identical within each respective harm level
- Participants answered 8 questions about post-situational feelings and reactions

Dependent Variables

- Relationship Damage (1-10)
- Relationship End (1-10)
- Long Term Forgiveness (1-10)
- Immediate Forgiveness (1-10)
- Level of Hurt (0-100%)
- Withdrawal (1-10)

Independent Variables

- 2 levels of Harm (Low vs High)
- 3 Relationship Types (BF, GF, BSF)
- 2 types of Participant Gender (F, M)
- 2 type of Offender Gender (F, M)

LOW HARM

“You recently started a side business/creative project you are deeply passionate about. Your best friend posted a “joke” about it on their large social media platform, implying your work is silly and destined to fail. The post gets dozens of embarrassing comments from their friends, making you feel ridiculed and undermining your confidence in your project.”

HIGH HARM

“You and your boyfriend are planning to move into a new shared space together next month. You have already paid the large security deposit in full. He secretly decides to back out of the lease and move in with a friend instead, leaving you with no way to recover their half of the deposit and unable to afford the new place alone.”

RESULTS

Table 1

Means of Dependent Variables for Low and High Harm Scenarios

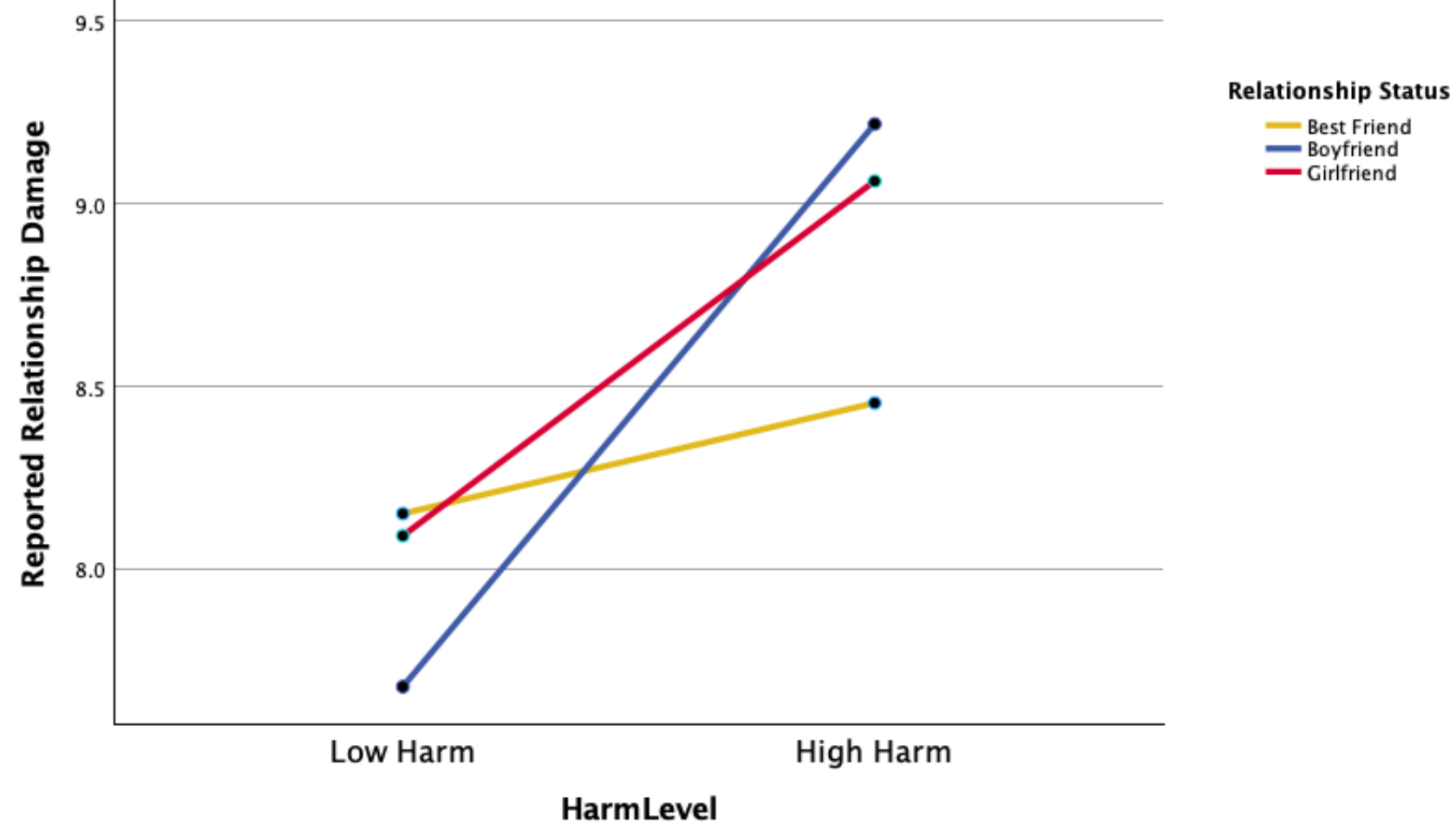
Dependent Variables	Low Harm Condition	High Harm Condition
Immediate Hurt (1-100)	82.67	91.68
Relationship Damage (1-10)	7.98	8.91
Long Term Forgiveness (1-10)	5.91	4.3
Relationship End (1-10)	5.44	7.19

Significant dependent variables and their mean differences between Low and High Harm conditions.

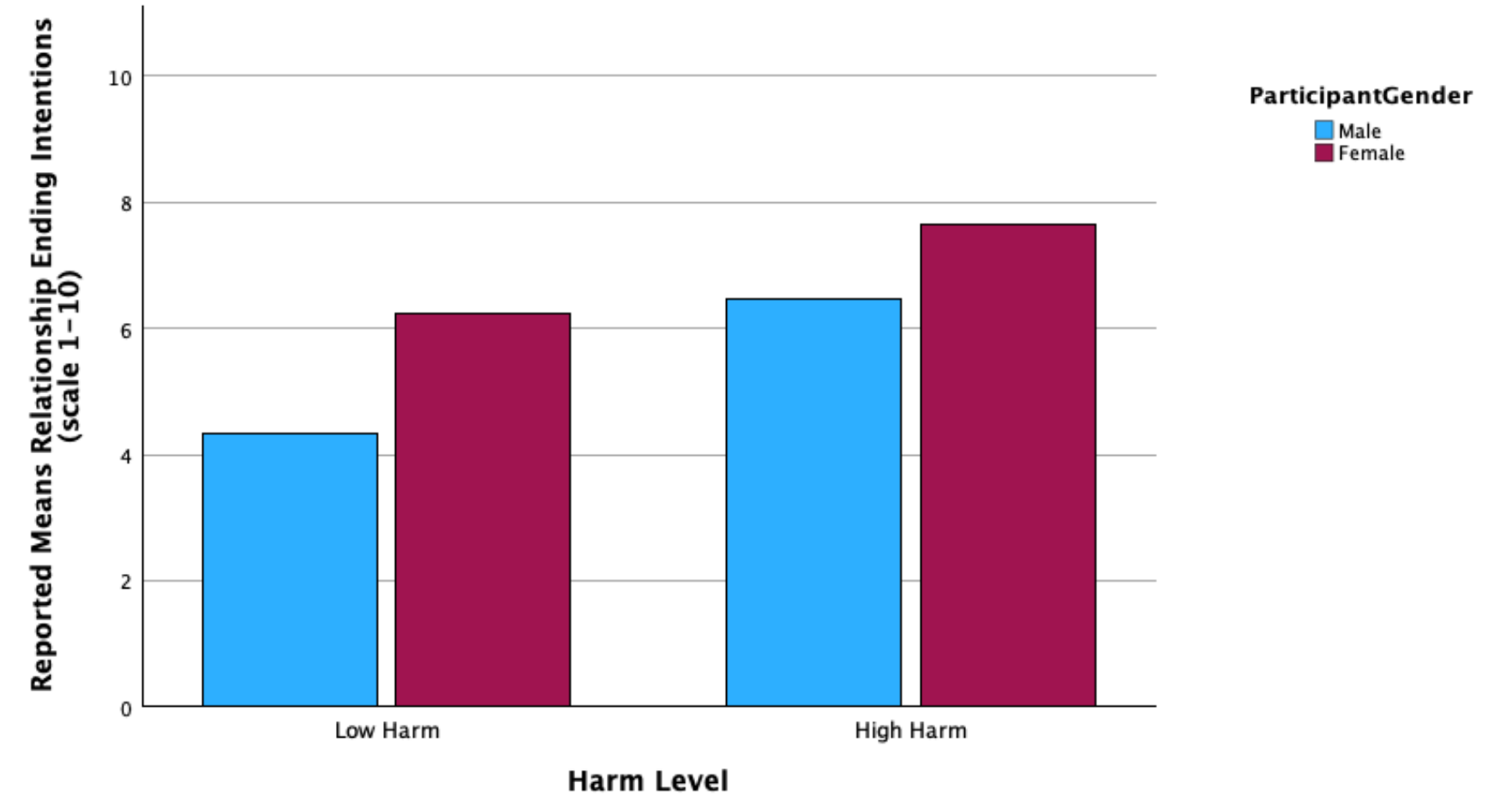
RESULTS



Interaction Effect of Harm Level and Relationship Type on Relationship Status



The Impact of Harm Level on Relationship End Likelihood for Male vs. Female Participants



Significant Effects of Harm Level x Relationship Status on Relationship Damage
($F = 3.760$, $p = .025$)

Gendered differences in intentions to end relationship separated by harm level

BEST FRIEND RESILIENCE



Interpretation: Best friend relationships are more resilient to harm severity.

Possible Reasons:

- We hold romantic partners to a higher standard of trust and commitment.
- The extended history of a friendship → situational mistake, not a character flaw (consistent with Aisyah & Agung, 2020).

○



GENDERED DIFFERENCES



- **Women are more lenient in judging relational damage when the offender is a female.** (no statistical difference between low and high harm)
- **Women are more likely to end a relationship after both low and high harm scenarios**



GENDERED DIFFERENCES

WHY?

- **in-group empathy**
- **Nature of the high harm scenario**
 - Financial betrayal culturally less expected from a female S/O
- **Women view unforgiveness as a means of protection**
 - Singh et al. (2025)



Limitations

Limited Sample

01

Heavily reliant on undergraduates from the 5cs, impacting generalizability

02

Data was a scenario read by participants, so not a genuine, lived experience

Participant x Offender Gender Overlap

03

If a female was given a girlfriend scenario, do they put themselves in a male's shoes, or assume they are in a same-gender relationship?

FUTURE RESEARCH?

- Replicate study using a more demographically diverse sample
- Dive deeper into the surprising resilience of close platonic friendships

